Be Involved in Your Health!

Other health problems that may affect your claudication

Arthritis, back pain, or depression symptoms may affect the amount of leg pain that you feel.

There is no evidence that walking with arthritis or back pain is bad for claudication. But you may have to slow down and take more breaks.

By itself, exercise helps patients with depression and arthritis .

For hip and knee arthritis, exercise improves pain and increases activity.

Please speak to your doctor about what to expect if you have these illnesses.

Quitting smoking is critical to improve your overall health and the blood flow to your legs.

Think of quitting now!

For **help with quitting smoking**, find support at:
1-800-QUIT-VET, 1-800-QUIT-NOW, or
www.smokefree.gov

For questions about VA services call:
MyVA311 at 844-698-2311

Things to Remember

- Tell your doctor if you get pain even when you are not walking.
- If you have diabetes, ask your doctor how to care for your feet.
- If you experience chest pain/pressure, trouble breathing, light-headedness, or nausea while walking, contact a doctor.
- If you feel really tired or have severe discomfort, **slow down.**
- Unless otherwise advised by your doctor, **drink plenty of water**.
- **Avoid** walking during the **hottest times of the day**.

Use these ***3 Spark Plug Items*** to start walking:

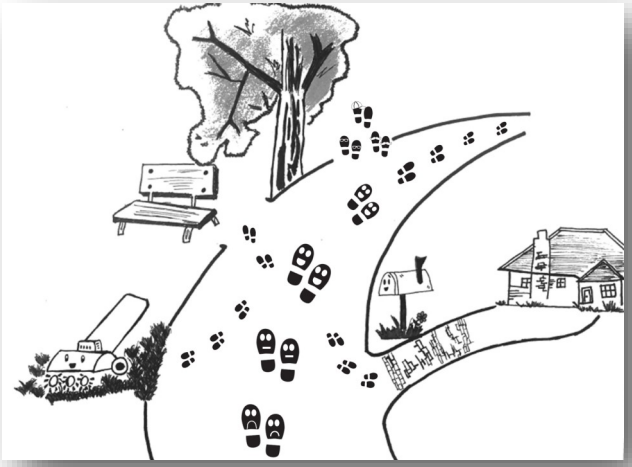
- **30 mins. a day** (or 10 or 20 mins.)
- **3 days a week**
- **3 weeks**

This material is informational and does **NOT** replace the advice of a doctor or other health care professional.

Written and illustrated by Neal R. Barshes, MD, MPH, Sherene Sharath, PhD, MPH, Nader Zamani, MD, MPH.

Staying Active with Claudication

Taking Steps to Reclaim the Activities that You Want to Do!



What is "claudication"?

Claudication is another way of saying "leg pain". It usually occurs in your thigh or calf when you walk, and goes away when you stop and rest.

What causes claudication?

Claudication is caused by low blood flow to the muscles. This means that the extra blood that you need when you are active does not reach the muscles.

Is claudication dangerous?

No. It's uncomfortable but the danger of losing your leg because of claudication is minimal. Walking for exercise will *not* make your leg pain worse.

How is it treated?

Research has shown that **exercise is a safe and effective way** to treat claudication.

When compared to surgical treatments (like angioplasty, stents, or bypass surgery), exercising:

- provides benefits that **last longer,**
- **increases** pain-free walking distance**,**
- has a **lower risk of amputation**, and
- has positive health impacts beyond just your leg pain.

Benefits of Walking

People who exercise regularly, for example by walking, could **double** the distance they walk without leg pain.

The human body has a way of "healing" itself. For claudication, walking helps your body to naturally build new arteries. This **increases blood flow** to your muscles and **decreases leg pain.**

How should I walk?

- Walk for **at least 30 minutes** on **3 or more days** per week.
- Have a dedicated "**walking time**"
- Wear comfortable shoes.

Start

- Walk at a comfortable pace.
- You should be able to talk while you walk.

Stop

- Stop when the pain in your leg becomes uncomfortable to you.
- Rest until the pain goes away. If you can, sit down.

Restart

- Start walking again.
- Take as many breaks as you need to reach your goal!

*You do **NOT** have to walk through the pain. Take a short break and start again.*

Where can I walk?

Walk in areas with places to stop and sit.

Walk inside your home

Walk outside - around your neighborhood or a local park

Walk around the grocery store with a shopping cart

Walk in and around the mall

Walk on a treadmill at the gym

Be Involved in Your Health!

You are the most important person who can take **steps** to improve your health. Here are some suggestions to overcome setbacks:

- If the weather is bad, try walking inside the house.
- Too much work? A break and a short 30 minute walk will help clear the mind!
- Walking is boring? Invite a buddy (or your dog or a buddy's dog)! Walking and talking may be more fun.